

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY OF LUANGWA COMMUNITY FORESTS PROJECT (REDD+ PROJECT IN ZAMBIA)

Overall information

The Luangwa Community Forests Project (LCFP) is a large-scale REDD+ grouped project with initial project area of 943,676 ha encompassing 12 Chiefdoms and 2 private ranches. It has now expanded to 1,236,258 ha with the addition of 6 new project areas in communal lands (within 5 new chiefdoms and 1 existing chiefdom) and 3 new project areas in private lands (Table 1; Figure 1). Project boundaries were defined with communities through Free and Prior Informed Consent (FPIC) and implementation is in partnership with the traditional authorities and the government of the Republic of Zambia.

The baseline scenario is ongoing unplanned deforestation driven primarily by subsistence agriculture. Furthermore, communities remain impoverished and biodiversity declines due to habitat loss and increased poaching. In the absence of the project, encroachment on the project area lands is likely to continue. The primary drivers of encroachment include charcoal making and subsistence farming.

Two project description deviations have been conducted during this monitoring period. Five data parameters required to measure emission reductions were mistakenly excluded from the validated Project Description document but were actually monitored throughout the current monitoring period, therefore this omission had no impact and these parameters have been described in each of the 5 VCS monitoring reports submitted to Verra. Secondly, due to the lack of details of the biodiversity monitoring activities provided in the validated Project Description document, and due to the delayed authorization from the Department of National Parks and Wildlife to conduct wildlife surveys within Game Management Areas, a detailed biodiversity monitoring plan effectively reflecting the activities conducted is provided in the monitoring report.

Climate

The climate objectives are to avoid deforestation in the project area and assist communities and biodiversity with climate change adaptation strategies through income diversification, improved farming techniques, crop diversification, and maintenance of habitat corridors.

Since the beginning of the project, the net estimated emission reductions in the project area measured against the without-project scenario elevates to 11,298,456 tCO₂e, which corresponds to 47,835 ha of reduced forest loss within the project area. The project also improved the management of 408.5 ha of farmland through the use of Climate Smart Agriculture technique.

Community

The project's community objective is instituting poverty alleviation activities benefiting at least 20,000 households, specifically targeting poor and vulnerable households.

The project has benefited to over 222,894 community members and since 2019 more than \$ 10 million cumulative payments have been made directly to the communities within the project areas. The project improved the livelihood of 28,631 community members, including 16,579 females, mainly through support in the agricultural sector, while 17,712 members (including 9,111 females) benefited from improved health services, 36,244 members (including 17,191 females) benefited from improved education service, and 26,915 members (including 13,968 females) experienced increased water quality and/or improved access

to drinking water. In terms of well-being, the project provided 120,386 distinct benefits as reported by the community members (including 60,302 benefits reported by females). As a result of the project capacity building activities, 1783 community members have improved skills and/or knowledge resulting from training, including 688 women.

The primary project activities designed and implemented to deliver the net positive outcomes related to community climate change adaptation, reducing vulnerability and increasing resilience of local communities include:

- Climate smart agriculture (CSA) where 1386 lead farmers have been trained and equipped, 408.5 ha effectively converted into CSA fields where yield experienced an increase of 80-175% for maize grain compared to the baseline.
- Honey production: a total of 9,538 beehives have been distributed, 6,020 kg of honey harvested and sold for a total amounting 7,900 USD. During the monitoring period the number of households that collected honey for sale and/or consumption or bought from others increased from 8.3% in 2020 to 14.33% in 2022.
- Improved horticulture farming. During the monitoring period over 172 lead farmers were trained in horticulture practices
- Poultry and livestock support programs with over 210 goats and 100 chickens distributed among 70 beneficiaries.
- Social services: During the monitoring period more than 200 community and 150 livelihood projects respectively, were implemented across the project area.

The project has delivered short-term and long-term human well-being benefits across all three areas of well-being outlined in the Attacking Poverty framework. These benefits include:

Opportunities: The project has created material opportunities for wealth creation and well-being through the payment of conservation fees, creation of jobs, alternative livelihoods through beekeeping activities, conservation farming activities and investment in infrastructure projects and improved educational conditions, as already detailed above.

Security: The project has enhanced the communities' security including tenure security, livelihood security, and capacity to adapt to climate change, notably by contributing to the legal designation of the first Community Forest Management Groups. During the monitoring period, 5 of the 17 CFMG's have applied for form 7 and obtained forest user rights.

Empowerment: The project has facilitated the empowerment of individuals and communities to participate in decisions related to use of conservation funds.

Overall, as per the 2022 follow-up Impact Evaluation of the LCFP, 75% of households sampled acknowledged benefitting from LCFP REDD+ activities, therefore demonstrating that the LCFP has a positive impact for the well-being of a large proportion of the community members. In terms of marginalized and vulnerable groups, 69% of female-headed households sampled and 11% of youth-elderly-physically impaired people reported to benefit from the LCFP livelihood projects.

The LCFP recognizes the importance of mainstreaming gender in the promotion of sustainable use and management of natural resources under a REDD+ project. In addition to the benefit reported above, other benefits that accrued to women include the direct employment of 23 female community scouts, participation of 58 women in the climate smart agriculture program, training of 688 female community members.

Biodiversity

The biodiversity objectives are maintaining a wildlife corridor between several national parks in the catchment of Zambia's 4th largest river system, conserving and maintaining vulnerable and endangered species through habitat protection and reduction in poaching.

Through conservation activities, enhancement of law enforcement measures and poverty alleviation, the project has been effective in managing 1,236,258 ha of the Luangwa river catchment area, improving the ecological integrity of this important wildlife corridor connecting five National Parks, which ultimately benefitted to the long-term conservation of the rich biodiversity of the area. This includes the largest hippopotamus population globally and other emblematic endemic and threatened species (3 species IUCN Red-Listed as Critically Endangered; 4 species as Endangered; 5 species as Vulnerable) such as African wild dogs, lions, elephants and giraffes to just say a few, and whose populations are remaining mostly stable as suggest the regular biodiversity surveys conducted by local stakeholders. Likewise, the LCFP biodiversity monitoring plan confirmed the presence in the project area of most High Conservation Values attributes related to species diversity and indicates that in Munyamadzi where regular monitoring took place since the start of the project, wildlife populations are mostly stable or increasing. The main biodiversity adaptation to climate change that the project is providing is by securing the long term conservation of a vast wildlife corridor along a north-south rainfall gradient and ensuring access of wildlife to critical water sources. The project also reduces the risk of destructive wildfires by implementing and promoting early dry season fire management systems. During this monitoring period, a fire management plan including firebreaks and early burning have been implemented to reduce the risk of wildfires

Table 1. Summary of Project Area: REDD+ Project Zones under communal tenure, for all three activity instances.

Project Activity Instance	Project Area Name (Tenure)	Game Management Area	Chiefdom	Project Area (ha)
1	Mpanshya (Communal)	Rufunsa	Mpanshya	84,530
1	Shikabeta (Communal)	Luano	Shikabeta	118,102
1	Mwanya (Communal)	Lower Lumimba	Mwanya	81,668
1	Luembe (Communal)	West Petauke	Luembe	288,726
1	Nyalugwe (Communal)	West Petauke	Nyalugwe	60,893
1	Msoro (Communal)	Lower Lupande	Msoro	24,688
1	Malama (Communal)	Lower Lupande	Malama	21,577
1	Mnkhanya (Communal)	Upper Lupande	Mnkhanya	33,623
1	Jumbe (Communal)	Upper Lupande	Jumbe	15,443
1	Nsefu (Communal)	Upper Lupande	Nsefu	39,801
1	Chitungulu (Communal)	Lumimba	Chitungulu	38,764
1	Sandwe (Communal)	Sandwe	Sandwe	92,362
1	Munyamadzi (Private)	-	Luembe	18,671
1	Pia Manzi (Private)	-	Nyalugwe	24,798
2	Mpanshya Corridor (Communal)	Rufunsa & Luano	Mpanshya & Shikabeta	15,271
2	Nyakolwe (Private)	-	Luembe	57,706

2	Nyamvu (Private)	-	Luembe	15,238
2	Kazumba (Private)	-	Luembe	4,775
3	Kazembe (Communal)	Upper Lumimba	Kazembe	18,515
3	Mwape (Communal)	Chisomo	Mwape	20,500
3	Chiawa (Communal)	Rufunsa	Chiawa	68,206
3	Mphuka (Communal)	Rufunsa	Mphuka	25,881
3	Mburuma (Communal)	Rufunsa	Mburuma	66,520
	Total			1,236,258

Project Title	Luangwa Community Forests Project (LCFP)
Project Location	Zambia, Eastern and Lusaka Provinces
Project Proponent(s)	BioCarbon Partners; Telephone: +260 211 290 051, Email: info@biocarbonpartners.com , Website: https://bcp.earth/
Verification Body	The Spanish Association for Standardisation and Certification (AENOR) ; Telephone: +34 914326000; Email: jfuentes@aenor.com ; Website: www.aenor.com
Project Lifetime	01-May-2015 to 30-April-2045; 30-year lifetime
GHG Accounting Period	01-May-2015 to 30-April-2045; 30-year lifetime
Monitoring Period of this Report	01-May-2015 to 31-December-2022
GHG Crediting Program	Verified Carbon Standard (VCS)
Sectorial Scope	Agriculture, Forestry, and Other Land Use (AFOLU)
Project Category	Reducing Emissions from Deforestation and Forest Degradation (REDD)
Baseline scenario	Unplanned mosaic or frontier deforestation (type F-U3)
History of CCB Status	CCB Validation: 2019
Gold Level Criteria	Community – improved livelihood and well-being of low income and vulnerable communities Climate – climate change adaptation through the diversification of income streams, resilient farming and the preservation of habitat corridors Biodiversity – improved protection of multiple threatened and endemic species

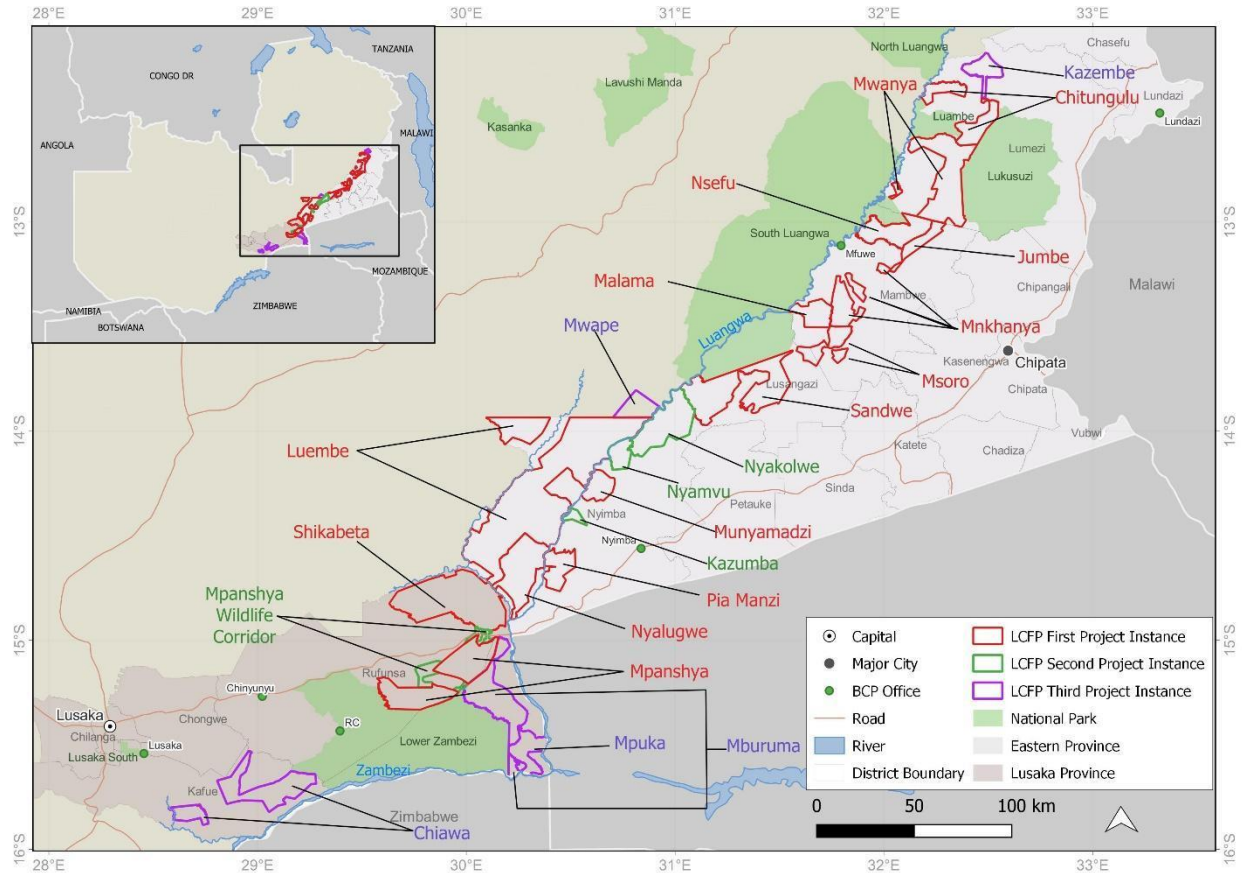


Figure 1. LCFP Project Areas